

Oral & Oropharyngeal Health: Lifestyle, Biological



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Why is oral health important?

- Oral health affects our ability to
 - Eat
 - Speak
 - Express emotions
- Oral health also affects a person's self-esteem, school performance, and attendance at work or school.

- Taking care of your oral health is an investment in your overall health.

Best practices that can keep oral cavity healthy

- Brush regularly (at least twice daily) with fluoride containing toothpaste, but not aggressively
- Floss once a day
- Use non-alcohol based mouth-rinse twice a week
- See a dentist for a check and cleaning, at least once in six months
- Limit sugary foods and drinks
- Do not use tobacco in any form (carcinogenic)
- Avoid use of alcohol (carcinogenic)
- Avoid unprotected oral sex (exposure to high/low risk HPV)

Systemic conditions linked to oral health

- **Endocarditis**: This infection of the inner lining of your heart chambers or valves occurs when bacteria from another part of your body, such as your mouth, spread through blood and attach to areas in the heart
- **Cardiovascular disease**: Some research suggests that heart disease and stroke might be linked to the inflammation and infections that oral bacteria can cause
- **Pregnancy and birth complications**: Periodontitis has been linked to premature birth and low birth weight.

- **Pneumonia**: Certain bacteria in the mouth can transit into the lungs, causing pneumonia and other respiratory diseases
- **Diabetes**: Gum disease appears to be more frequent and severe among people who have diabetes
And persons with gum disease have a harder time controlling their blood sugar levels
- **HIV/AIDS**: Oral problems, such as painful mucosal lesions, are common in people who have HIV/AIDS

Conclusion

- Interest in oral immunology has heightened because of the link between oral and systemic diseases
 - E.g. activation of immune cells such as monocytes by plaque bacteria may contribute to the development of atherosclerosis

